

Search engines

Search engines are integral parts of the online experience. They help people efficiently filter through the vast world of the internet to find what they're looking for.

What are search engines?

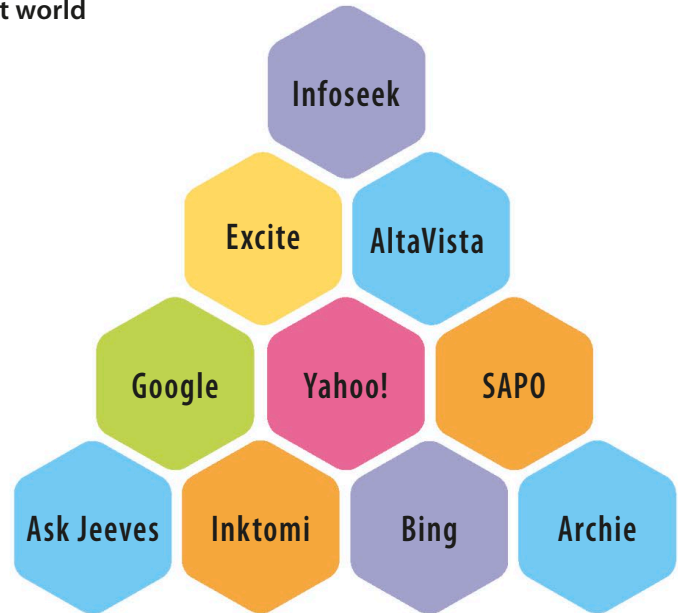
A search engine is a program that looks through the world wide web for webpages containing particular words or phrases. In the early days of the web, there were so few sites that search engines weren't really necessary. As the number of websites increased, there was a need to be able to efficiently search the web. The number of search engines competing to do this job peaked in the late 1990s.

► Early search engines

Archie, launched in 1990, was the first web content search engine. It was followed by others, including Excite, Infoseek, Inktomi, AltaVista, and Yahoo. Google appeared only in 1998, but quickly overtook all other sites by using new and more effective ways of searching the web.

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Setting a default search engine

Search engines are not all the same, and some users might prefer one over the rest. The method for setting a default search engine varies slightly for each browser and can change with browser updates. The best way to find out how to do this is to use a search engine to search for “set default search engine” along with a specific browsing program. The graphic below shows how to set a default search engine in two of the most popular browsers.

